CLAUDE IMPACT LAB · CHALLENGE BRIEF

UCI × SoCal Affordable Housing

Saturday, November 7, 2026 · Paul Merage School of Business, UC Irvine

In Orange County, a median home costs about **$1.47 million**, and only about **15%** of households can afford one. (C.A.R., Q3 2026)

That leaves teachers, nurses, firefighters and the kids who grew up here two choices: leave, or commute an hour or more each way.

Nonprofits that build affordable **ownership** homes do exist. So do community land trusts, faith communities with land, employers trying to house their own workforce, and city housing offices. They all face the same equation, and in OC the cost side usually wins by six figures per home.

> Moreover, their solutions are small scale, often one-off projects. **Scale is missing. Is it attainable?**

EVERY HOME HAS TO BALANCE

What the family can afford to pay	+	Public subsidies	+	Fundraising	−	The cost to create the home	=	$0
FIXED BY INCOME		LANE 3 · FUND IT		LANE 3 · FUND IT		LANE 1 · FIND IT (LAND) LANE 2 · CLEAR IT (TIME)		

ABOUT FOUR YEARS FROM FINDING LAND TO HANDING OVER KEYS · EVERY MONTH ADDS COST

Rezoning · ~1 yr	Entitlements · ~1 yr	Plans · 6–12 mo	Build · ~1 yr

Lanes 1 and 2 shrink the cost; Lane 3 closes the gap. Each lane describes **the problem, not the answer.** Pick the one your team cares about most.

LANE 1 · FIND IT Where can the next affordable home go?

THE REAL PROBLEM

Nonprofits mostly find sites by luck: a city calls about surplus land, or a church offers its parking lot. Meanwhile California has passed a wave of laws that open up land that used to be off-limits:

- **SB 9** single-family lot splits
- **SB 684 / 1123** up to 10 homes, no hearing
- **AB 2011** commercial corridors
- **SB 4** faith and college land
- Condo conversions

The laws are public and so is the parcel data, but nobody has connected the two in a way a small nonprofit can use.

And a legal site isn't always a usable one. Teams still need to know who owns it and whether they'd sell, whether it can actually be built on (slope, contamination, fire or flood zones, water and sewer capacity), and whether a nonprofit can move before a market-rate buyer does. Land is the biggest line on the bill.

WHO'S STUCK

A nonprofit acquisitions lead with no GIS team, a congregation sitting on an underused lot, or city housing staff.

THE OPEN QUESTION

The laws are public. The parcel data is public. So why does finding a site still come down to luck, and what would change that?

LANE 2 · CLEAR IT

How do we turn four years into two?

THE REAL PROBLEM

Time is cost. Builders who have done it describe a path that can cut the timeline to about two years: start on land that's already zoned correctly, get a **ministerial** approval (if you meet the written rules, the city must say yes, with no hearing and no discretion), and use state-approved plans.

The obstacle is finding that path. Every one of OC's 34 cities has its own forms, fees and checklists. City forms sometimes misread state law, and the state housing department (HCD) regularly issues letters telling cities they got it wrong.

And approval is only one delay. Projects also wait on plan-check corrections, utility and fire sign-offs, funding rounds that open once a year, condo map paperwork and relocating tenants. Every month of waiting costs money.

WHO'S STUCK

A nonprofit project manager, a small builder, a homeowner adding an ADU, or a city permit tech who wants to get it right.

THE OPEN QUESTION

The fast path exists on paper. Why is it so hard to find and follow in practice, and what would make it the normal path instead of the rare one?

LANE 3 · FUND IT

Does it pencil, and who closes the gap?

THE REAL PROBLEM

Developers say a project "pencils" when the numbers work. Affordable ownership almost never pencils on its own. The family's price is capped by income: housing costs should stay around 30–35% of what they earn, so the price can't rise to cover cost.

The gap gets filled from many sources: city, state and federal programs (CalHome, HOME, local housing funds), down-payment programs, lenders, employers, donors, and earned revenue such as donated-goods resale. Today that stack gets assembled by hand, one project at a time.

WHO'S STUCK

A nonprofit finance lead, a development director, a donor, or a city housing analyst.

THE OPEN QUESTION

Every project has a gap. What makes it smaller, or makes the money that closes it easier to find?

THE CLOSING QUESTION · AFTER AWARDS

If we combined the best Find + Clear + Fund tools from today, could one affordable home in Orange County hit $0?

Worked example: one home's bill · mock numbers, rounded, based on a typical project

COST TO CREATE	$535K
Land and building purchase LANE 1 · FIND IT	**$360k**
Time costs while waiting LANE 2 · CLEAR IT loan interest, taxes, insurance, management	**$85k**
Construction and repairs	**$40k**
Fees, design, legal, sales	**$50k**

PAID BY	$535K
Family's price FIXED BY INCOME	**$285k**
Public subsidies LANE 3 · FUND IT	**$100k**
Rent earned while waiting LANE 3 · FUND IT earned income	**$55k**
Fundraising: the gap LANE 3 · FUND IT	**$95k**

Paid by – cost to create = **$0**. When this project's schedule slipped 10 months, the fundraising it needed grew **about 7 times**. Time is money on both sides of the equation.

Before you build

1. **Start with one real person** and the problem they're stuck on. Show their before and after.
2. **Bend the brief if it serves the goal.** Teams may go outside these lanes as long as the result helps get more affordable homes built in Southern California.
3. **Play fair with data.** Public or provided data only. Don't overload or abuse city websites, and don't use private plans, blueprints or personal information without permission.

How judges score

Impact
A nonprofit or city would use it next month to help get homes built.

Works
Live demo on real data, sources shown.

Scale
A believable path to the next 100 projects.

Innovation
A new way to see or solve the problem.

Starter data · a few places to start. There's much more out there, and the best teams find sources nobody else used.

LAND AND ZONING
SCAG regional parcel and Housing Element site-inventory maps (scag.ca.gov) · OC and city open-data GIS parcel layers · HCD Statewide Surplus Land Inventory

RULES
HCD SB 9 fact sheet · state text for SB 684/1123, AB 2011, SB 4 (leginfo.legislature.ca.gov) · city ADU checklists and fee schedules (public PDFs) · HCD Housing Accountability Unit letters to cities

MONEY
HCD 2026 State Income Limits for Orange County (use the June 23, 2026 revision) · Freddie Mac mortgage rate · CalHome / CalHFA down-payment programs

PROGRESS
HCD 6th-cycle RHNA progress data (data.ca.gov, updated biweekly) shows how far each city is behind its housing target

A REAL CASE TO TEST AGAINST
Any publicly listed small building or lot in OC (about 4–12 homes): new build, rehab or conversion. Label assumed numbers.

Hub claudesocal.com/uci-impact-lab · **Starter repo** github.com/travcjohnson/claude-impact-lab-uci